> It has been reported to the Managing Directors that you went with Dr Van Langenberg to the Co[mpan]y's office late on Saturday evening (21st inst.) and asked the Establishment present then to produce the Share Register for your inspection, offering a rupee as fee and showing a section of the Co[mpan]y's Act under which fines could be imposed for refusing to allow inspection. It is not known whether your purpose was official or otherwise. The incident however has scared the Establishment at the present juncture, and their superiors feel that if you had written to them to say that you wished to inspect the Register, they would have been glad to welcome you at any time during office hours. On Saturday the Clerk in charge of the Register is reported to have left before your visit which was after office hours. The Co[mpan]y is always prepared to allow inspection of the Register during such hours to members as well as non-members.[30]

In an atmosphere of 'so much scare' Ashe's overture terrified the lower-level staff, as K.R. Guruswami Aiyar explained in some detail to the governor a week later. 'He asked the Doctor to bear witness. He offers the rupee and threatens the man with a fine. What is the purpose? If the share register was wanted a single letter would have got him that.'[31] This incident infuriated even a loyalist like K.R. Guruswami Aiyar.

There were also reports that European merchants were interfering with traders and brokers transacting business with the Tuticorin branch of the Madras Bank and planting misinformation about the finances of SSNCo. So distressing was the situation that the local merchants complained to the bank authorities in Madras.[32] The European merchants created other troubles as well. Apparently, they used covert methods to obstruct the payment of Rs 47,000 towards the *Gallia*'s dues.[33]

If *The Hindu* reported all these under the rubric of 'Official Oppression in Tuticorin', the *Amrita Bazar Patrika*, from far-off Calcutta, called a spade a spade: 'Reign of Terror in Tinnevelly. The Swadeshi Company the Target'.[34]

Nearly two months later, *The Hindu*, on its editorial page, carried a fuller report by 'a well-informed Tuticorin correspondent' on 'the unsympathetic attitude and petty persecutions on the part of some of the local Government servants'. Ashe, even though he had been transferred to Godavari district a month earlier (on 17 April), was excoriated at some length. His action against the six Tuticorin vakils drew scathing criticism. Much was made of